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WHEN PAT BROWN COMMISSIONED a television commercial in which he told a group of small children, “I’m running against an actor, and you know who killed Abe Lincoln, don’t you?,” I knew he knew he was in trouble.

I won the chance to run against Brown after a Republican primary campaign that was very bitter at times, largely because of the lingering split between conservatives and moderates in the state party.

My principal opponent in the primary was George Christopher, a former mayor of San Francisco who tried simultaneously to portray me as a right-wing extremist and attack me because I’d admitted having been in Communist front groups—without mentioning that I’d resigned and declared war on them as soon as I’d realized what they were.

I was a novice in politics and at times I showed it. At a convention of black Republicans, I made my talk, sat down, and was followed by Christopher, who got up and implied during his speech that I was a racial bigot.

I fumed about it for a moment or two, stood up, and said (some people there say I *shouted)* to Christopher that he was wrong, that I’d never been a bigot and I deeply resented his attack on my integrity. Then I walked off the stage and drove home, leaving a startled audience behind me.

During almost thirty years in Hollywood, I had become accustomed to taking potshots from critics. But I’d grown up in a home where no sin was more grievous than racial bigotry, and I wasn’t going to take it from Christopher.